

Emergent Vacuum Response in Coherent Nonequilibrium Electromagnetic Systems

Erick S. Sangalang

*Independent Researcher**

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Abstract

This paper presents a consolidated formulation of Emergent Vacuum Response Theory (EVRT) as a constrained phenomenological framework for investigating whether coherent nonequilibrium electromagnetic systems may exhibit narrowly constrained, potentially measurable, resonance-dependent deviations from ordinary linear electromagnetic response. The model introduces an effective pseudoscalar response coordinate, interpreted not as a confirmed fundamental particle but as a coarse-grained collective order parameter associated with unresolved microscopic or mesoscopic vacuum configurations. The framework is constructed to preserve gauge invariance, charge conservation, conservation of stress-energy when all sectors are included, and continuous recovery of Maxwell electrodynamics in the weak-coupling, incoherent, off-resonant, or strongly damped limits.

The present paper addresses four core scientific objections: why such effects would not already be observed under ordinary conditions; how the apparent parameter freedom can be reduced through dimensionless control variables; how the framework differs experimentally from conventional axion-like electrodynamics; and why propulsion or reactionless-thrust interpretations are outside the scope of the model. A minimal falsification experiment and a simulation-to-observable mapping are proposed using a high-Q cavity under controlled temperature, magnetic-field, and frequency sweeps. The most defensible observables are delayed ringdown, linewidth broadening, phase lag, temperature-dependent response, and geometry-dependent cavity scaling. No claim is made of anti-gravity, reactionless propulsion, vacuum-energy extraction, or violation of established conservation laws.

The framework is therefore structured not to assert new physics, but to enable decisive experimental discrimination within a narrowly defined parameter space.

Keywords: nonequilibrium electrodynamics; emergent vacuum response; pseudoscalar susceptibility; resonant cavities; vacuum birefringence; phase lag; delayed ringdown; falsifiability; effective field theory

* ORCID: 0009-0009-4039-2815

I. INTRODUCTION

Classical electrodynamics and quantum electrodynamics remain among the most successful physical theories ever developed. Any proposed extension of their low-energy behavior must therefore be narrow, conservative, and explicitly falsifiable. The purpose of EVRT is not to replace Maxwell electrodynamics or quantum electrodynamics, but to formulate a testable effective-response hypothesis: under sufficiently coherent, resonant, and nonequilibrium electromagnetic conditions, the vacuum can be tested for an effective phenomenological response rather than assumed to possess a weak collective susceptibility sector.

The central question is not whether ordinary electromagnetic systems exhibit large unexplained forces. They do not. The central question is instead whether specially prepared coherent electromagnetic systems can reveal small, reproducible, resonance-selective deviations in observables such as cavity ringdown, phase response, linewidth, temperature dependence, or field-overlap scaling.

This work represents a consolidated synthesis of prior exploratory analyses into a single constrained and experimentally testable framework. It narrows the framework to a minimal mathematical structure, identifies suppression mechanisms, distinguishes EVRT from axion-like particle models, and proposes a decisive experimental pathway. The preferred scientific outcome is not confirmation but discrimination: the framework should either produce a constrained observable signature or be ruled out by carefully designed null experiments.

II. CORE EFFECTIVE FRAMEWORK

The minimal phenomenological interaction is written as

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{int}} = g\phi F_{\mu\nu}\tilde{F}^{\mu\nu}, \quad (1)$$

where $F_{\mu\nu}$ is the electromagnetic field tensor, $\tilde{F}^{\mu\nu}$ is its dual, g is an effective coupling coefficient, and $\phi(x, t)$ is an emergent pseudoscalar response coordinate. Because

$$F_{\mu\nu}\tilde{F}^{\mu\nu} \propto \mathbf{E} \cdot \mathbf{B}, \quad (2)$$

the source term is parity-sensitive. In EVRT, ϕ is interpreted as a coarse-grained collective coordinate rather than as a verified new fundamental particle.

A minimal driven-damped response equation is

$$\square\phi + \Gamma\partial_t\phi + m_\phi^2\phi + \lambda\phi^3 = g\mathbf{E} \cdot \mathbf{B}, \quad (3)$$

where m_ϕ is an effective response scale, Γ is a damping coefficient, and λ controls nonlinear saturation. The weak-field linear limit is obtained by setting $\lambda\phi^3$ negligible.

For monochromatic excitation, the linear susceptibility is

$$\chi_\phi(\omega) = \frac{1}{m_\phi^2 - \omega^2 - i\Gamma\omega}. \quad (4)$$

This expression provides the central organizing principle for EVRT: any candidate effect should be suppressed away from resonance, broadened by damping, and absent in the weak-coupling limit.

III. WHY THE EFFECT WOULD NOT ALREADY BE SEEN

A viable effective-response framework must explain why ordinary experiments do not already show the proposed response. EVRT imposes four suppression mechanisms.

A. Off-Resonance Suppression

Equation 4 implies that the response is strongly reduced when ω is far from m_ϕ . In normalized form, with $\Omega = \omega/m_\phi$ and $\gamma = \Gamma/m_\phi$,

$$|\chi_\phi| \propto [(1 - \Omega^2)^2 + \gamma^2\Omega^2]^{-1/2}. \quad (5)$$

Thus, broad nonresonant electromagnetic environments are not expected to activate a persistent response.

B. Coherence Suppression

The response is hypothesized to require coherent driving. A simple phenomenological coherence factor can be written as

$$C \sim \frac{\tau_{\text{coh}}}{\tau_{\text{drive}}} \quad (6)$$

for $\tau_{\text{coh}} < \tau_{\text{drive}}$, with saturation near unity for highly coherent excitation. In incoherent thermal or broadband environments, microscopic parity-sensitive biases average toward zero.

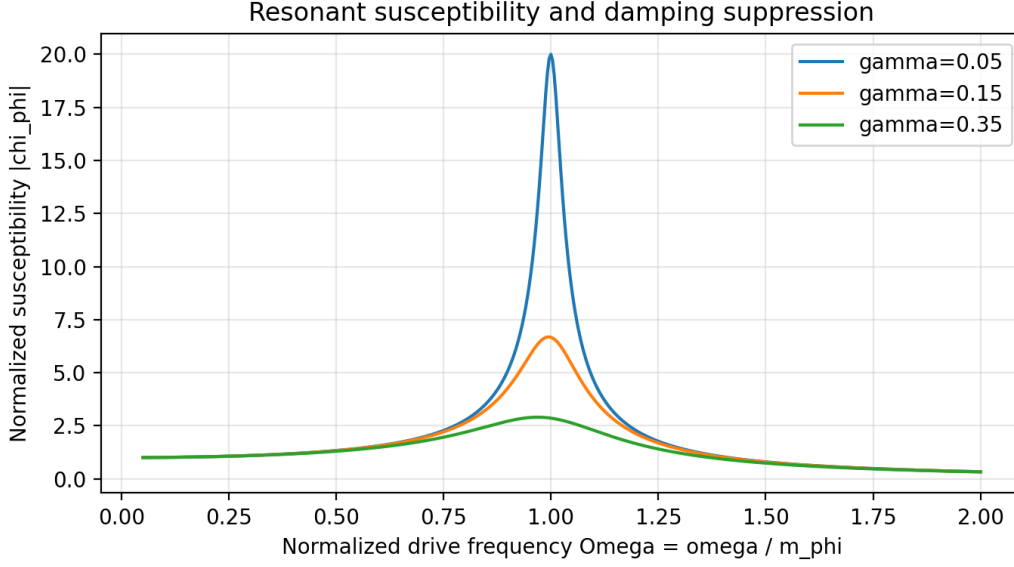


FIG. 1. Illustrative normalized susceptibility for several damping values. Lower damping produces sharper resonant response; larger damping broadens and suppresses it.

C. Temperature Suppression

A statistical interpretation motivates an effective free energy of the form

$$F(\phi, T) = U(\phi) - TS(\phi). \quad (7)$$

If the entropy expansion contributes a positive quadratic term, the effective mass may scale as

$$m_\phi^2(T) = m_0^2 + cT. \quad (8)$$

The linear response then becomes

$$\phi \approx \frac{g(\mathbf{E} \cdot \mathbf{B})}{m_0^2 + cT}. \quad (9)$$

In the simplified entropic limit $m_0^2 \ll cT$,

$$\phi \propto \frac{\mathbf{E} \cdot \mathbf{B}}{T}. \quad (10)$$

Room-temperature incoherent environments are therefore expected to suppress the response relative to cryogenic coherent systems.

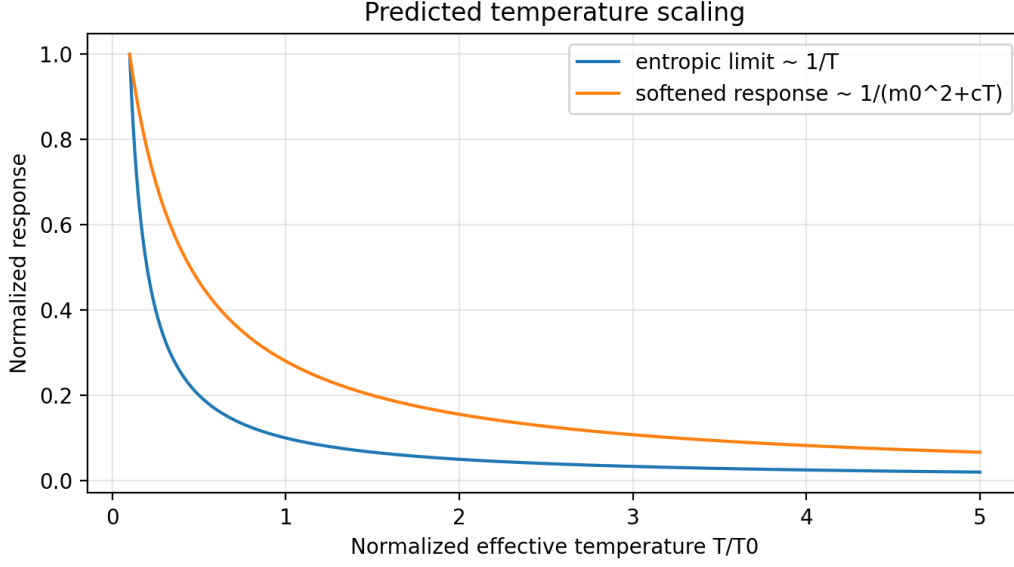


FIG. 2. Illustrative temperature scaling. A softened curve is represented by a nonzero baseline mass scale; both versions predict stronger response at lower effective temperature.

D. Geometric and Correlation-Length Suppression

If the response has a finite correlation length

$$\xi \sim m_\phi^{-1}, \quad (11)$$

efficient cavity coupling requires the characteristic cavity length L and field-overlap structure to be comparable to ξ . If $L \ll \xi$, the cavity may not sample the spatial variation effectively. If $L \gg \xi$, uncorrelated domains may average down the response. This creates a natural reason why only specific resonator geometries would be relevant.

IV. REDUCED DIMENSIONLESS PARAMETER SPACE

A common criticism of phenomenological models is excessive parameter freedom. EVRT reduces its observable behavior to a small number of dimensionless groups:

$$\epsilon = \frac{gE_0B_0}{m_\phi^2}, \quad \gamma = \frac{\Gamma}{m_\phi}, \quad \Omega = \frac{\omega}{m_\phi}, \quad \Lambda = \frac{\lambda\phi_0^2}{m_\phi^2}. \quad (12)$$

Here ϵ controls drive strength, γ controls damping, Ω controls detuning, and Λ controls nonlinear saturation. In the linear regime, $\Lambda \ll 1$, the primary parameter space collapses to $(\epsilon, \gamma, \Omega)$.

TABLE I. Dimensionless regimes and expected behavior.

Condition	Regime	Expected behavior
$\epsilon \ll 1$	weak drive	negligible response
$\Omega \approx 1$	near resonance	enhanced susceptibility
$\Omega \not\approx 1$	off resonance	suppressed response
$\gamma \ll 1$	low damping	sharp linewidth, longer ringdown
$\gamma \gtrsim 1$	strong damping	broad, weak, rapidly decaying response
$\Lambda \ll 1$	linear	no hysteresis or saturation
$\Lambda \sim 1$	nonlinear	possible threshold, saturation, and hysteresis

This reduction is important because it converts EVRT from an open-ended speculative claim into a restricted response model. The framework becomes vulnerable to exclusion if experiments systematically scan these dimensionless regimes and observe no predicted scaling.

V. DISTINCTION FROM AXION-LIKE ELECTRODYNAMICS

The coupling $\phi F \tilde{F}$ resembles axion and axion-like-particle electrodynamics. EVRT must therefore identify distinguishing features. The distinction is not mathematical at the interaction-symbol level; it is physical and experimental. These distinctions are operational and intended to guide experimental discrimination.

TABLE II. Conceptual distinction between conventional axion-like models and EVRT.

Axion-like particle models	EVRT
Particle-like field	Emergent collective response
Apparatus-independent field	Coherence-activated response
Particle mass and coupling	State-dependent effective response
Conversion signatures	Ringdown, phase, linewidth, temperature scaling
No generic T^{-1} scaling	Inverse-temperature scaling as a core test

Three distinguishing experimental predictions are central:

1. a temperature-dependent response approximately following Eq. 10;
2. delayed ringdown or phase lag beyond ordinary cavity loss;
3. geometry dependence through L/ξ and field-overlap factors.

If these distinguishing signatures are absent under controlled conditions, EVRT loses its primary reason to be considered separately from ordinary constrained axion-like phenomenology.

VI. NONLINEAR NONEQUILIBRIUM BEHAVIOR

At stronger drive, the nonlinear term in Eq. 3 can be approximated by a Duffing-type oscillator for a coherent mode:

$$\ddot{\phi} + \Gamma\dot{\phi} + m_\phi^2\phi + \lambda\phi^3 = S_0 \cos(\omega t), \quad (13)$$

where $S_0 = gE_0B_0$. The sign and magnitude of λ determine whether the resonance hardens or softens with amplitude. Possible observable consequences include amplitude-dependent resonance shift, hysteresis, threshold-like activation, linewidth changes, phase lag, and delayed relaxation.

These nonlinear behaviors are not presented as evidence for new physics by themselves. Similar dynamics occur in many conventional driven systems. Their value is diagnostic: EVRT predicts a specific combination of nonlinearity, temperature scaling, $E \cdot B$ dependence, and geometry dependence. Any claimed observation must survive comparison against ordinary nonlinear electromagnetic, thermal, mechanical, and material effects.

VII. CONSERVATION AND NON-PROPULSION SCOPE

EVRT does not propose reactionless propulsion, gravitational shielding, net momentum creation, or vacuum-energy extraction. A conservation-compatible effective stress tensor may be written schematically as

$$T_{\text{eff}}^{\mu\nu} = T_{\text{EM}}^{\mu\nu} + T_\phi^{\mu\nu} + T_{\text{int}}^{\mu\nu}, \quad (14)$$

with

$$\partial_\mu T_{\text{eff}}^{\mu\nu} = 0 \quad (15)$$

when all fields, materials, boundaries, supports, radiation leakage, and environmental couplings are included. Therefore, the preferred observables are not thrust claims but conservative electromagnetic response observables: ringdown, phase, linewidth, birefringence, field-overlap scaling, and thermal dependence.

The removal of propulsion language is not cosmetic. It is scientifically necessary. Force-like interpretations are vulnerable to thermal recoil, Lorentz coupling, cable forces, electrostatic interaction, vibration, residual gas effects, and sensor drift. Those effects should be treated as artifacts unless excluded quantitatively by vacuum, reversal, dummy-load, and blind-analysis protocols.

VIII. MINIMAL DECISIVE EXPERIMENT

The most direct falsification pathway is a resonant cavity experiment designed around response observables rather than propulsion claims.

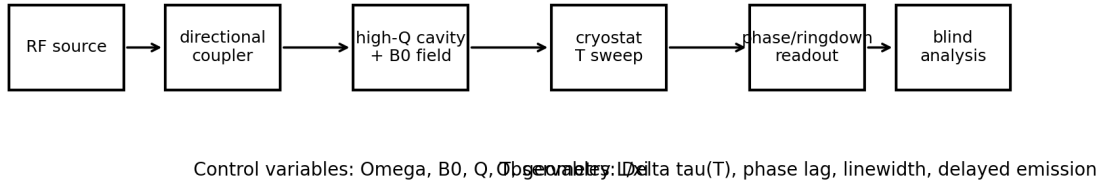


FIG. 3. Minimal experimental architecture for falsifying EVRT through conservative cavity-response observables.

A. Core Setup

A minimal experimentally credible platform should include:

- a high-Q microwave or superconducting resonator;
- a controlled static magnetic field B_0 to generate nonzero $\mathbf{E} \cdot \mathbf{B}$ overlap;

- cryogenic temperature control;
- calibrated phase and ringdown readout;
- dummy-load and zero-field controls;
- blind drive sequences and independent replication.

B. Primary Observables

The strongest observables are:

1. ringdown deviation $\Delta\tau(T)$;
2. phase lag relative to Maxwellian cavity response;
3. linewidth broadening or narrowing near candidate resonance;
4. scaling with B_0^2 or $E \cdot B$;
5. geometry dependence through L/ξ .

A representative phenomenological test relation is

$$\tau_{\text{eff}} = \tau_{\text{Maxwell}} + \Delta\tau(T, B_0, \Omega, L/\xi), \quad (16)$$

with the proposed low-order scaling

$$\Delta\tau \propto \frac{B_0^2}{T} f(\Omega, \gamma) \mathcal{G}(L/\xi), \quad (17)$$

where f captures resonance and damping, while $\mathcal{G}$ captures geometry and overlap.

C. Primary Discriminating Observable

Among the candidate observables, temperature-dependent deviation in cavity ringdown is the most robust single-variable test. The proposed leading-order discriminating behavior is

$$\Delta\tau \propto \frac{B_0^2}{T}. \quad (18)$$

This relation serves as the primary falsifiable signature of EVRT, because it combines temperature scaling, resonance selectivity, and magnetic-field dependence in a form not reproduced by conventional cavity loss mechanisms.

This scaling provides a direct experimental discriminator because ordinary cavity losses, thermal drift, dielectric relaxation, and readout artifacts are not expected to reproduce the same simultaneous inverse-temperature, resonance-selective, and B_0^2 -dependent behavior under controlled conditions.

D. Order-of-Magnitude Detectability

For a resonant cavity with quality factor Q and angular frequency ω , the conventional ringdown time scales as

$$\tau_{\text{cav}} \sim \frac{Q}{\omega}. \quad (19)$$

A representative fractional deviation may be written as

$$\frac{\Delta\tau}{\tau_{\text{cav}}} \sim \epsilon f(\Omega, \gamma) \mathcal{G}(L/\xi), \quad (20)$$

where $\epsilon = gE_0B_0/m_\phi^2$ is the normalized drive strength, $f(\Omega, \gamma)$ captures detuning and damping, and $\mathcal{G}(L/\xi)$ captures geometry and field-overlap effects. Detectability therefore requires resolving fractional deviations below the experimental noise floor while independently controlling temperature, magnetic field, resonance detuning, and geometry.

In practical systems, resolving such deviations requires stability and measurement precision at the level of fractional changes in ringdown time. Modern high-Q cavity and resonator metrology systems can reach very small fractional stability windows depending on frequency, temperature control, coupling architecture, and readout noise. The detectability of EVRT-like signatures therefore depends on whether the effective coupling produces deviations within or above the experimentally calibrated sensitivity band.

This places EVRT-like signals at the edge of modern cavity metrology sensitivity, rather than in an obviously detectable regime.

The absolute magnitude of the predicted effect depends on the unknown effective coupling scale. The estimates and plots in this section should therefore be interpreted as sensitivity and scaling guides rather than calibrated signal predictions.

E. Signal-to-Noise Considerations

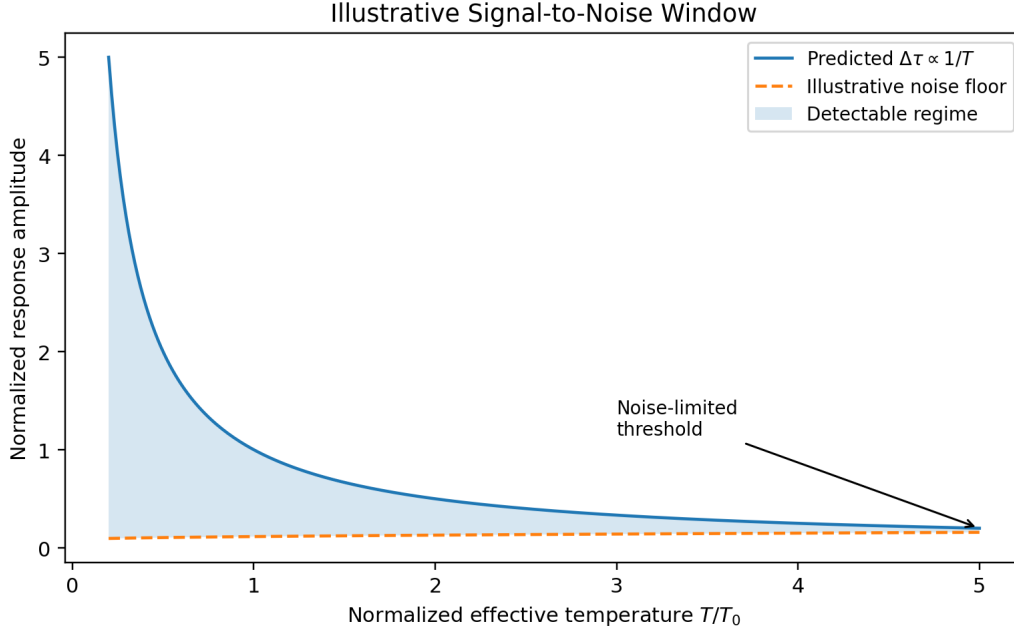


FIG. 4. Illustrative comparison between a normalized predicted signal $\Delta\tau \propto 1/T$ and a representative noise floor. The region where the predicted response exceeds the noise floor represents the qualitative experimental window in which a temperature-dependent ringdown deviation could be resolved. The plot is schematic and intended to show scaling behavior, not a calibrated absolute signal.

This representation emphasizes that detectability depends not only on the presence of a candidate signal, but on its separation from calibrated noise under controlled parameter sweeps.

A useful experimental design principle is to perform temperature sweeps at fixed cavity geometry, fixed drive conditions, and fixed B_0 , then repeat the sweep under zero-field and dummy-load controls. A valid candidate signal would need to show a reproducible temperature-dependent separation from the calibrated noise floor while disappearing or changing predictably under control conditions.

F. Scaling with Quality Factor and Magnetic Field

To leading order, sensitivity improves with both cavity storage time and magnetic-field strength. The simplest experimental scaling can be represented as

$$\Delta\tau \propto B_0^2 Q, \quad (21)$$

with all other parameters held fixed. This scaling is expected to hold only within the linear response regime and may break down under strong nonlinear driving or saturation effects. This does not imply that arbitrarily increasing Q or B_0 guarantees a signal; it only identifies the direction in which experimental sensitivity should improve if the phenomenological response exists.

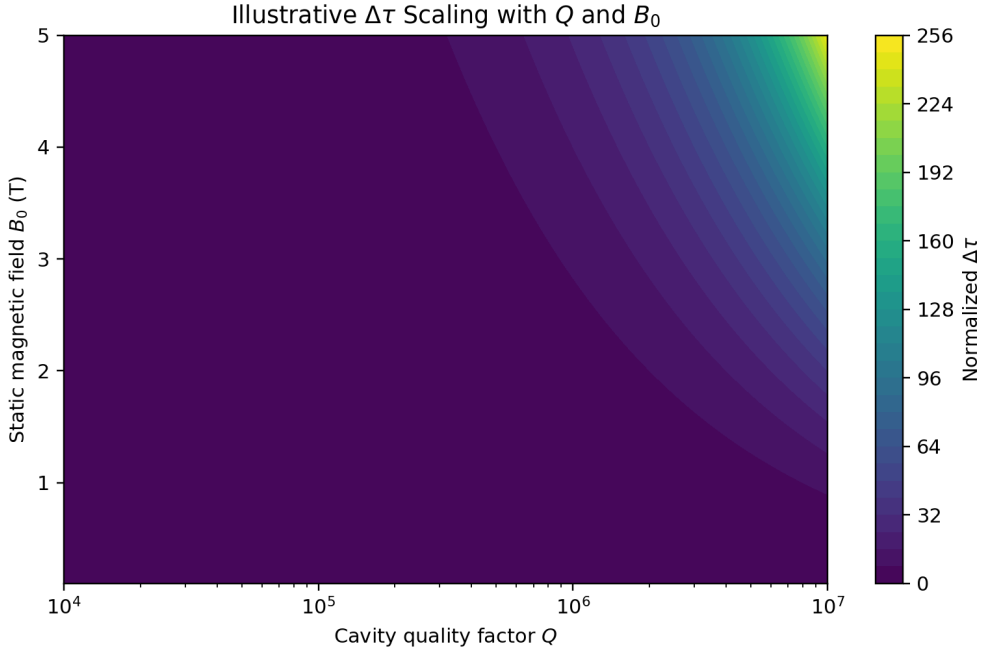


FIG. 5. Illustrative contour plot showing normalized $\Delta\tau$ scaling with cavity quality factor Q and static magnetic field B_0 . Higher- Q cavities and stronger magnetic fields improve sensitivity in the proposed scaling model, but practical limits from thermal stability, vibration, magnetic compatibility, and readout noise must be included in any real apparatus design.

G. Integrated Measurement Strategy

A complete experimental run should include:

1. a baseline Maxwellian ringdown calibration at $B_0 = 0$;
2. a frequency sweep through the candidate resonance window $\Omega \approx 1$;
3. a temperature sweep at fixed Q , B_0 , drive amplitude, and geometry;
4. repeated B_0 sweeps to test the expected B_0^2 dependence;
5. dummy-load, detuned-cavity, and geometry-control runs;
6. blind activation sequences and independent replication of any candidate residual.

This integrated sequence is designed to separate a genuine EVRT-like response from ordinary cavity loss, cryogenic drift, dielectric relaxation, RF leakage, and instrumentation bias.

A reduced-order numerical model can be used prior to experiment to map these observables across controlled parameter sweeps. By comparing a Maxwellian baseline against a weakly coupled EVRT response, one can test for bounded, reproducible deviations in ringdown, phase, and linewidth before committing to a full experimental implementation. Such simulations are not evidence of new physics, but serve as a consistency check that the proposed framework yields distinguishable signatures under realistic conditions.

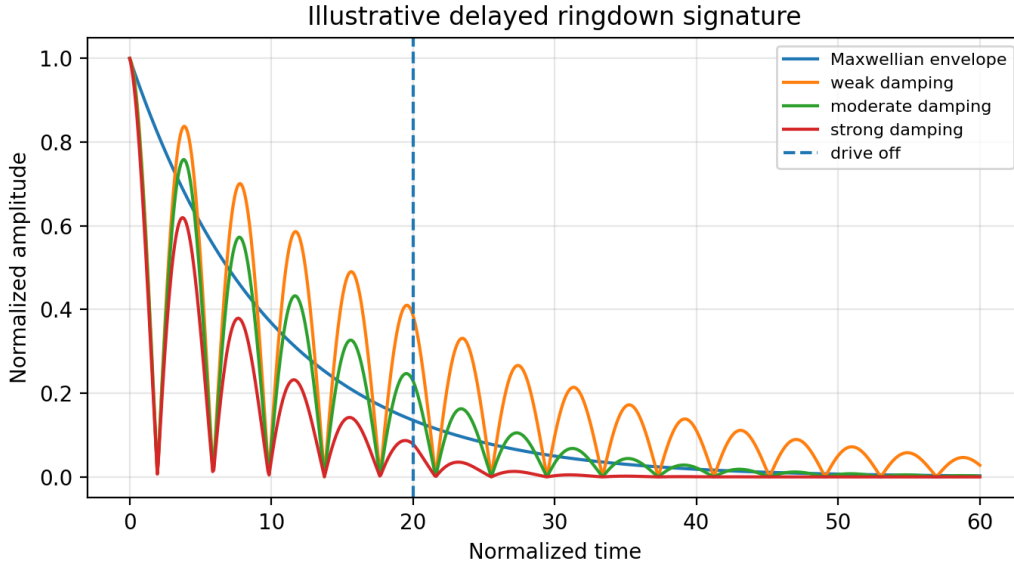


FIG. 6. Schematic ringdown comparison. A valid signal would require a reproducible, temperature- and resonance-dependent deviation beyond ordinary cavity losses and thermal artifacts.

IX. NON-UNIQUE SIGNATURES AND FALSE POSITIVES

Several conventional effects can mimic candidate EVRT-like signatures and must not be interpreted as evidence without quantitative exclusion. These include:

- thermal drift, cryostat transients, and radiometric effects;
- dielectric relaxation, charging, and material hysteresis;
- conventional nonlinear cavity response or mode hopping;
- Lorentz coupling, cable forces, vibration, and magnetic pickup;
- RF leakage, ground loops, readout saturation, and instrumentation bias.

A candidate signal should therefore be treated as provisional unless it survives zero-field controls, dummy-load substitution, detuned-cavity comparison, temperature reversal or cycling, magnetic-field scaling tests, and blind analysis. The combination of inverse-temperature behavior, resonance selectivity, B_0^2 scaling, delayed ringdown, and geometry dependence is more important than any single signature in isolation.

X. FALSIFICATION CRITERIA

EVRT is weakened or falsified if controlled experiments show:

1. no temperature-dependent response beyond ordinary material and thermal effects;
2. no resonance enhancement near candidate m_ϕ scales;
3. no delayed ringdown beyond calibrated Maxwellian cavity decay;
4. no reproducible dependence on $\mathbf{E} \cdot \mathbf{B}$ or B_0^2 ;
5. no geometry dependence consistent with a finite correlation length;
6. any apparent signal disappears under dummy-load, zero-field, reversal, or blind-analysis controls.

A positive result would not immediately establish a fundamental new field, but would instead indicate a reproducible, parameter-dependent deviation from standard electromagnetic response requiring further cross-platform verification.

A robust null result is scientifically valuable because it constrains g , m_ϕ , Γ , λ , and ξ within the experimental sensitivity band.

XI. RELATION TO EXISTING EXPERIMENTS

Several existing experimental platforms operate in regimes partially overlapping the EVRT parameter space, including superconducting microwave cavities, axion haloscope experiments, precision vacuum-birefringence measurements, and high-Q resonator metrology platforms. These systems approach parts of the proposed parameter space, but they do not perform the combined resonance, coherence, temperature, and magnetic-field scaling sweeps required for a decisive EVRT test.

EVRT differs from conventional axion-like searches in that its primary proposed observables are cavity-response quantities such as ringdown deviation, phase lag, linewidth changes, inverse-temperature scaling, and field-overlap dependence rather than particle-conversion signatures alone.

Existing experiments may therefore constrain portions of the framework without fully excluding the specific nonequilibrium regime proposed here, since they do not perform the combined resonance, coherence, temperature, and magnetic-field scaling sweeps required for a decisive EVRT test.

A decisive test requires simultaneous control of resonance, coherence, temperature, and magnetic-field scaling within a single experimental platform.

XII. LIMITATIONS

Several limitations remain. First, EVRT is phenomenological and does not provide a completed microscopic theory of vacuum structure. Second, the parameters g , m_ϕ , Γ , λ , and ξ must be experimentally constrained rather than assumed. Third, existing precision electrodynamic, cavity, birefringence, and axion-like searches already restrict large regions of possible parameter space. Fourth, ordinary thermal, material, and instrumental artifacts

can mimic several candidate observables and must be excluded quantitatively.

A result is considered nontrivial only if it (i) remains bounded and stable, (ii) recovers the Maxwellian limit when $\epsilon \rightarrow 0$, and (iii) shows reproducible deviations in $\Delta\tau$, phase, linewidth, and the combined scalings (B_0^2 , T , geometry). Otherwise, the framework is weakened prior to any costly laboratory test.

XIII. CONCLUSION

EVRT is best understood as a constrained falsifiability program, not as a claim of established new physics. Its strongest formulation avoids propulsion claims and focuses instead on conservative electromagnetic response observables in coherent nonequilibrium systems. The framework predicts resonance selectivity, damping-dependent susceptibility, temperature-dependent response, delayed ringdown, phase lag, and geometry-dependent scaling. These signatures are sufficiently concrete to be tested and, if absent, to constrain or rule out the model.

The next decisive step is not further theoretical extension, but precision experimental discrimination within the constrained parameter space defined here.

The scientific value of the framework lies in its direct vulnerability to experimental falsification. The framework is therefore best understood as an experimentally testable hypothesis, whose value lies in its capacity to be decisively confirmed or excluded. A final assessment should not depend on rhetorical plausibility, but on reproducible experimental discrimination in high-Q resonant systems under controlled temperature, magnetic-field, and geometry sweeps.

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